

UNCLASSIFIED

BY ORDER OF THE
SECRETARY OF THE AIR
FORCE

**DEPARTMENT OF THE AIR
FORCE**
**AIR FORCE INSTRUCTION 36-
2618**



OCTOBER 13, 2025

The Enlisted Force Structure

**AIRMAN AND FAMILY
READINESS**

Version 1.0

COMPLIANCE WITH THIS PUBLICATION IS MANDATORY

DISTRIBUTION: DISTRIBUTION STATEMENT A: Approved for public release; distribution unlimited

ACCESSIBILITY: Publications and forms are available on the e-Publishing website at <http://www.e-publishing.af.mil>.

RELEASABILITY: There are no releasability restrictions on this publication.

EFFECTIVE DATE: OCTOBER 13, 2025 **REVIEW DATE:** OCTOBER 13, 2026

POC: Lt Col Smith, John A.
DSN: 555-1234 | Commercial: (555) 555-1234
Email: john.a.smith@us.af.mil

OPR: SAF/IG

Certified by: AF/CV
(General Larry O. Spencer)

UNCLASSIFIED

TABLE OF CONTENTS

1. Operational Protocols	3
1.1 Standard Operating Procedures	3
1.1.1 Initial Setup and Pre-flight Checks	3
1.1.1.1 Equipment Inspection	3
1.1.1.2 Calibration Procedures	3
1.1.2 Flight Operations	3
1.1.2.1 Mission Planning	3
1.1.2.2 Flight Execution	3
1.2 Maintenance Protocols	3
1.2.1 Routine Maintenance	3
1.2.1.1 Scheduled Inspections	3
1.2.1.2 Component Replacement	3
1.2.2 Emergency Maintenance	3
1.2.2.1 Rapid Response Protocols	3
1.2.2.2 Spare Parts Management	3
2. Safety and Compliance	3
2.1 Risk Management	3
2.1.1 Hazard Identification	3
2.1.1.1 Risk Assessment Procedures	3
2.1.1.2 Mitigation Strategies	3
2.1.2 Safety Protocols	3
2.1.2.1 Personal Protective Equipment (PPE)	3
2.1.2.2 Safety Drills and Training	3
2.2 Compliance and Audits	3
2.2.1 Regulatory Compliance	3
2.2.1.1 Adherence to Standards	3
2.2.1.2 Audit Procedures	3
2.2.2 Accountability	3
2.2.2.1 Roles and Responsibilities	3

2.2.2.2 Reporting and Documentation	3
3. Communications and Coordination	3
3.1 Communication Protocols	3
3.1.1 Internal Communications	3
3.1.1.1 Communication Systems	3
3.1.1.2 Coordination Meetings	3
3.1.2 External Communications	3
3.1.2.1 Liaison with External Agencies	3
3.1.2.2 Public Relations	3

1. Operational Protocols

1.1 *Standard Operating Procedures*

1.1.1 Initial Setup and Pre-flight Checks

1.1.1.1 Equipment Inspection

1.1.1.1.1. Before each flight operation, a thorough inspection of all UAS equipment must be conducted to ensure airworthiness and operational readiness. This inspection involves checking the structural integrity of the airframe, verifying the functionality of control surfaces, and ensuring that all electronic systems are fully operational. Personnel must pay particular attention to the battery health, as compromised batteries can lead to catastrophic failures. Note: Visual inspection should be complemented by diagnostic tests using approved software to detect any underlying issues not visible to the naked eye.

1.1.1.1.2. The inspection process must be documented in the UAS maintenance log, with any discrepancies reported immediately to the commanding officer. Personnel responsible for the inspection must certify the completion of all checks prior to flight authorization. WARNING: Failure to perform a comprehensive pre-flight inspection could result in mission failure and potential loss of the UAS. Adherence to the inspection protocol is mandatory and subject to periodic audits.

1.1.1.2 Calibration Procedures

1.1.1.2.1. Calibration of UAS systems is crucial for ensuring accurate navigation and sensor data collection. This includes the calibration of onboard gyroscopes, accelerometers, and GPS modules. The calibration process must be conducted in an environment free from electromagnetic interference to ensure data integrity. Personnel must follow the calibration procedures as outlined in the manufacturer's manual, adjusting settings as necessary to adapt to specific mission parameters. CAUTION: Improper calibration can lead to navigation errors and compromised mission data.

1.1.1.2.2. Post-calibration, a test flight should be conducted to validate the accuracy of the calibration adjustments. During this test, operators should assess flight stability and sensor accuracy, making further adjustments if necessary. The results of the test flight must be recorded and reviewed as part of the mission briefing process. Compliance with calibration standards is essential for mission success and operational safety.

1.1.2 Flight Operations

1.1.2.1 Mission Planning

1.1.2.1.1. Detailed mission planning is a critical component of UAS operations, requiring coordination across multiple departments. The planning phase involves defining mission objectives, determining flight paths, and identifying potential hazards. Personnel must utilize mission planning software to simulate flight paths and assess risk factors. This phase

also includes securing the necessary airspace permissions and coordinating with air traffic control when operating in controlled airspace.

1.1.2.1.1.2. Pre-mission briefings must be conducted with all involved personnel to review mission objectives, flight plans, and safety protocols. The briefing should outline contingency plans for potential emergencies, including communication failures or unforeseen weather conditions. Personnel must ensure all mission details are documented and accessible to all team members. Note: Effective communication is essential for the successful execution of mission objectives.

1.1.2.2 Flight Execution

1.1.2.2.1.1. During flight execution, constant monitoring of UAS systems is required to ensure optimal performance and safety. Operators must maintain communication with the ground control station, reporting any anomalies immediately. The flight crew is responsible for adjusting flight paths in response to dynamic environmental conditions, such as sudden weather changes. Table 1 outlines the standard operating conditions and response protocols for in-flight adjustments.

1.1.2.2.1.2. Post-flight analysis is a mandatory procedure to assess mission success and identify areas for improvement. This includes reviewing flight logs, sensor data, and mission outcomes. Personnel must document any deviations from the planned flight path and analyze factors contributing to such deviations. The findings from the post-flight analysis should be integrated into future mission planning to enhance operational efficiency and safety.

1.2 Maintenance Protocols

1.2.1 Routine Maintenance

1.2.1.1 Scheduled Inspections

1.2.1.1.1.1. Scheduled inspections are essential to maintain the operational integrity of UAS systems. Inspections must be conducted at regular intervals as specified by the maintenance schedule, which is based on flight hours and operational conditions. This process includes a comprehensive review of mechanical components, electronic systems, and software integrity. Personnel conducting the inspections must be certified and adhere to Air Force maintenance standards.

1.2.1.1.1.2. All inspection results must be documented in the UAS maintenance log, with any required repairs or adjustments noted and addressed promptly. The maintenance supervisor is responsible for ensuring the completion and accuracy of all documentation. **WARNING:** Neglecting scheduled maintenance can lead to system failures and jeopardize mission success. Compliance with maintenance protocols is non-negotiable and subject to regular audits.

1.2.1.2 Component Replacement

1.2.1.2.1.1. Component replacement is necessary when parts reach the end of their service life or are damaged. The process involves identifying worn or defective components, sourcing approved replacements, and ensuring compatibility with existing systems. Personnel must follow manufacturer guidelines and Air Force standards when replacing components, documenting each replacement in the maintenance log. Note: Only authorized personnel may perform component replacements to ensure system integrity and safety.

1.2.1.2.1.2. The replacement process should include testing the new component to verify proper installation and functionality. Any anomalies detected during testing must be addressed before the UAS is returned to operational status. The maintenance supervisor is responsible for certifying the completion of the replacement process and approving the UAS for flight operations. Compliance with replacement procedures is crucial to ensure the safety and reliability of UAS systems.

1.2.2 Emergency Maintenance

1.2.2.1 Rapid Response Protocols

1.2.2.1.1.1. In the event of a system failure or unexpected issue, rapid response protocols must be initiated to minimize downtime and restore operational capability. These protocols involve immediate assessment of the situation, identification of the fault, and deployment of maintenance personnel to address the issue. Communication with mission control is essential to coordinate efforts and provide updates on repair progress. CAUTION: Personnel must prioritize safety and adhere to emergency response procedures during repairs.

1.2.2.1.1.2. Post-repair, a comprehensive system check is required to ensure the resolution of the issue and prevent recurrence. This includes testing all affected systems and conducting a brief test flight if necessary. Documentation of the emergency maintenance process must be thorough, detailing the nature of the issue, corrective actions taken, and any recommendations for future prevention. Compliance with emergency maintenance protocols is vital for maintaining mission readiness and operational safety.

1.2.2.2 Spare Parts Management

1.2.2.2.1.1. Effective spare parts management is critical for ensuring the availability of necessary components during emergency maintenance. This involves maintaining an accurate inventory of spare parts, forecasting demand based on usage patterns, and ensuring timely restocking. The logistics officer is responsible for managing the spare parts inventory and coordinating with suppliers to prevent shortages. Table 2 provides a list of critical spare parts and recommended stock levels.

1.2.2.2.1.2. Inventory audits must be conducted regularly to verify stock levels and identify discrepancies. Any shortages must be addressed immediately to prevent operational delays. Personnel handling spare parts must be trained in inventory management procedures and adhere to Air Force logistics standards. Compliance with spare parts management protocols ensures the availability of components critical to maintaining UAS operational readiness.

2. Safety and Compliance

2.1 Risk Management

2.1.1 Hazard Identification

2.1.1.1 Risk Assessment Procedures

2.1.1.1.1.1. Effective risk management begins with the identification and assessment of potential hazards associated with UAS operations. This involves conducting a comprehensive risk assessment prior to each mission, evaluating factors such as environmental conditions, operational complexity, and personnel readiness. The risk assessment should be documented and reviewed by the mission commander to ensure all identified risks are addressed and mitigated.

2.1.1.1.1.2. Personnel conducting the risk assessment must be trained in risk management techniques and familiar with the operational environment. The assessment should include input from all relevant departments, ensuring a holistic understanding of potential risks. Compliance with risk assessment procedures is mandatory to safeguard personnel and equipment, and to ensure mission success. Table 3 outlines the standard risk assessment criteria and scoring system.

2.1.1.2 Mitigation Strategies

2.1.1.2.1.1. Mitigation strategies are essential for reducing the potential impact of identified risks. These strategies may include altering flight paths, adjusting mission timing to avoid adverse weather, and implementing additional safety measures. Personnel must develop mitigation plans in collaboration with the mission commander, ensuring all strategies are feasible and effective. CAUTION: All mitigation strategies must be tested and validated prior to implementation to ensure their effectiveness.

2.1.1.2.1.2. The success of mitigation strategies must be evaluated post-mission, with findings documented and used to refine future risk management plans. Lessons learned from each mission should be shared across units to enhance overall safety and operational efficiency. Compliance with mitigation strategies is crucial for minimizing risk exposure and protecting Air Force assets. Note: Continuous improvement in risk management practices is essential for maintaining a high standard of operational safety.

2.1.2 Safety Protocols

2.1.2.1 Personal Protective Equipment (PPE)

2.1.2.1.1.1. The use of personal protective equipment (PPE) is mandatory for all personnel involved in UAS operations. PPE requirements vary based on the nature of the operation, with standard gear including helmets, gloves, and safety goggles. Personnel must be trained in the proper use and maintenance of PPE, ensuring it is worn correctly at all times. The safety officer is responsible for verifying compliance with PPE protocols and addressing any violations.

2.1.2.1.1.2. PPE must be inspected regularly for signs of wear or damage, with replacements procured as necessary to maintain effectiveness. Personnel are responsible for reporting any issues with their PPE to the safety officer immediately. Compliance with PPE protocols is critical for protecting personnel from injury and ensuring safe operation of UAS systems. WARNING: Failure to adhere to PPE requirements can result in disciplinary action and increased risk of injury.

2.1.2.2 Safety Drills and Training

2.1.2.2.1.1. Regular safety drills and training sessions are essential for preparing personnel to respond effectively to emergencies. These sessions should simulate realistic scenarios, providing hands-on experience in managing potential crises. Training should cover emergency response procedures, communication protocols, and the use of safety equipment. The training officer is responsible for organizing and conducting these sessions, ensuring all personnel are adequately prepared.

2.1.2.2.1.2. Participation in safety drills is mandatory for all personnel, with attendance documented and reviewed by the training officer. Feedback from participants should be used to improve the effectiveness of future training sessions. Compliance with safety drill requirements is crucial for ensuring personnel readiness and enhancing overall safety. Continuous improvement in safety training practices is necessary to adapt to evolving operational environments and maintain high safety standards.

2.2 Compliance and Audits

2.2.1 Regulatory Compliance

2.2.1.1 Adherence to Standards

2.2.1.1.1.1. Adherence to regulatory standards is mandatory for all UAS operations, ensuring compliance with Air Force directives and federal regulations. Personnel must familiarize themselves with relevant standards and incorporate them into operational procedures. The compliance officer is responsible for monitoring adherence and reporting any deviations to the command structure. Table 4 lists the key regulatory standards applicable to UAS operations.

2.2.1.1.1.2. Regular training and updates are necessary to keep personnel informed of changes to regulatory standards. Compliance audits should be conducted periodically to assess adherence and identify areas for improvement. Personnel must cooperate fully with audit processes, providing documentation and access to operations as required. Compliance with regulatory standards is essential for maintaining operational legitimacy and avoiding legal repercussions.

2.2.1.2 Audit Procedures

2.2.1.2.1.1. Audit procedures are designed to verify compliance with operational and regulatory standards, identifying areas for improvement and ensuring accountability. Audits should be conducted by qualified personnel with a comprehensive understanding of UAS

documentation, observing operations, and interviewing personnel to assess compliance levels.

2.2.1.2.1.2. Findings from audits should be documented in a comprehensive report, detailing any non-compliance issues and providing recommendations for corrective actions. The audit report must be reviewed by the command structure, with follow-up actions taken to address identified issues. Compliance with audit procedures is critical for maintaining operational integrity and ensuring continuous improvement in UAS operations.

2.2.2 Accountability

2.2.2.1 Roles and Responsibilities

2.2.2.1.1.1. Clear delineation of roles and responsibilities is essential for ensuring accountability in UAS operations. Personnel must understand their specific duties and the expectations associated with their roles. The command structure should provide clear guidance on roles and responsibilities, ensuring all personnel are aware of their obligations. Table 5 outlines the key roles and responsibilities for UAS operations.

2.2.2.1.1.2. Accountability mechanisms should be in place to monitor performance and address any deviations from established standards. Personnel must be held accountable for their actions, with consequences for non-compliance clearly defined. Compliance with accountability frameworks is crucial for maintaining operational discipline and ensuring mission success. Continuous improvement in accountability practices is necessary to adapt to evolving operational environments and maintain high standards of performance.

2.2.2.2 Reporting and Documentation

2.2.2.2.1.1. Accurate reporting and documentation are essential components of accountability in UAS operations. Personnel must maintain comprehensive records of all operations, including flight logs, maintenance records, and compliance documentation. The documentation process should be standardized and accessible to all relevant personnel, ensuring transparency and accountability. Compliance with reporting and documentation requirements is critical for maintaining operational integrity and ensuring accountability.

2.2.2.2.1.2. Regular reviews of documentation should be conducted to verify accuracy and completeness, with any discrepancies addressed promptly. Personnel must cooperate fully with documentation reviews, providing access to records as required. Compliance with reporting and documentation requirements is essential for ensuring accountability and maintaining operational legitimacy. Continuous improvement in documentation practices is necessary to adapt to evolving operational environments and maintain high standards of performance.

3. Communications and Coordination

3.1 Communication Protocols

3.1.1 Internal Communications

3.1.1.1 Communication Systems

3.1.1.1.1. Effective internal communication is crucial for coordinating UAS operations and ensuring mission success. Communication systems must be reliable and capable of supporting real-time data exchange among all personnel involved in the operation. Personnel must be trained in the use of communication systems, ensuring proficiency and adherence to communication protocols. Compliance with communication protocols is essential for maintaining operational efficiency and ensuring mission success.

3.1.1.1.2. Regular testing of communication systems should be conducted to verify functionality and address any issues promptly. Personnel must report any communication system malfunctions immediately to ensure timely resolution. Compliance with communication system maintenance protocols is critical for maintaining operational readiness and ensuring mission success. Continuous improvement in communication practices is necessary to adapt to evolving operational environments and maintain high standards of performance.

3.1.1.2 Coordination Meetings

3.1.1.2.1. Regular coordination meetings are essential for ensuring alignment among all personnel involved in UAS operations. These meetings provide an opportunity to review mission objectives, discuss challenges, and coordinate efforts. Personnel must attend coordination meetings as scheduled, with attendance documented and reviewed by the command structure. Compliance with coordination meeting protocols is crucial for maintaining operational efficiency and ensuring mission success.

3.1.1.2.2. Feedback from coordination meetings should be used to improve communication practices and enhance overall operational efficiency. Personnel must be encouraged to share insights and suggestions for improvement, fostering a culture of continuous improvement. Compliance with communication and coordination protocols is essential for maintaining operational efficiency and ensuring mission success. Continuous improvement in communication practices is necessary to adapt to evolving operational environments and maintain high standards of performance.

3.1.2 External Communications

3.1.2.1 Liaison with External Agencies

3.1.2.1.1. Effective liaison with external agencies is essential for coordinating UAS operations in complex environments. Personnel must establish and maintain communication with relevant agencies, ensuring alignment and coordination. The liaison officer is responsible for managing external communications and ensuring compliance with

communication protocols. Compliance with external communication protocols is critical for maintaining operational efficiency and ensuring mission success.

3.1.2.1.1.2. Regular communication with external agencies should be maintained, with updates provided as necessary to ensure alignment and coordination. Personnel must be trained in external communication protocols, ensuring proficiency and adherence to standards. Compliance with external communication protocols is essential for maintaining operational efficiency and ensuring mission success. Continuous improvement in external communication practices is necessary to adapt to evolving operational environments and maintain high standards of performance.

3.1.2.2 Public Relations

3.1.2.2.1.1. Public relations efforts are essential for maintaining a positive image and fostering support for UAS operations. Personnel must engage with the public in a professional manner, providing accurate information and addressing concerns. The public relations officer is responsible for managing public communications and ensuring compliance with communication protocols. Compliance with public relations protocols is critical for maintaining operational efficiency and ensuring mission success.

3.1.2.2.1.2. Regular public relations efforts should be conducted, with updates provided as necessary to ensure alignment and coordination. Personnel must be trained in public relations protocols, ensuring proficiency and adherence to standards. Compliance with public relations protocols is essential for maintaining operational efficiency and ensuring mission success. Continuous improvement in public relations practices is necessary to adapt to evolving operational environments and maintain high standards of performance.

REFERENCES

1. DoD Directive 5000.01, "The Defense Acquisition System," September 9, 2020
2. DoD Instruction 5000.02, "Operation of the Adaptive Acquisition Framework," January 23, 2020
3. AFI 33-360, "Publications and Forms Management," December 7, 2018
4. AFMAN 33-363, "Management of Records," March 1, 2008
5. DAFI 90-160, "Publications and Forms Management," April 14, 2022
6. Federal Records Act, 44 U.S.C. Chapters 29, 31, and 33
7. Privacy Act of 1974, 5 U.S.C. 552a
8. Freedom of Information Act (FOIA), 5 U.S.C. 552

GLOSSARY OF TERMS AND ACRONYMS

Air Force Instruction

AFMAN

Air Force Manual

AFPD

Air Force Policy Directive

DAFI

Department of the Air Force Instruction

DoD

Department of Defense

DSN

Defense Switched Network

IAW

In Accordance With

OPR

Office of Primary Responsibility

OCR

Office of Collateral Responsibility

POC

Point of Contact

RDS

Records Disposition Schedule

SECAF

Secretary of the Air Force

ATTACHMENTS

1. Attachment 1: Implementation Timeline

2. Attachment 2: Compliance Checklist

3. Attachment 3: Process Flow Diagram

DISTRIBUTION LIST

ACTION ADDRESSEES:

- All Major Commands (MAJCOM)
- All Field Commands
- All Direct Reporting Units (DRU)

INFORMATION ADDRESSEES:

- Air National Guard (ANG)
- Air Force Reserve Command (AFRC)
- Air Force Space Command (AFSPC)

COPIES FURNISHED TO:

- Office of the Secretary of Defense
- Joint Chiefs of Staff
- Department of the Army
- Department of the Navy